

The Phoenix Program

Surprised by the ferocity and breadth of the Tet Offensive, the US examined the role of intelligence in the war. The result was the Phoenix Program, a systematic drive to destroy the political structure of the Viet Cong and root out communist sympathizers.

◀◀ BEFORE

The Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) was involved in Indochina long before the first US military advisers or troops arrived.

OPS AND ASSASSINATIONS

The CIA opened its first covert station in Saigon in 1954. A year later, the agency laid the initial groundwork for a “secret war” in Laos against communist forces that would last for nearly 20 years.

Under **Project Tiger**, the agency inserted South Vietnamese spies into North Vietnam from the late 1950s. CIA agents also helped plan the coup that **toppled the government of President Diem** in November 1963.

Set up by the CIA under President Johnson, the Phoenix Program (Phung Hoang in Vietnamese) was an attempt to boost intelligence efforts in South Vietnam. Active from July 1968 as part of the CORDS pacification program, Phoenix targeted the Viet Cong’s political and administrative structures, known as the VCI (Viet Cong Infrastructure). The Phoenix Program’s mandate went much further than previous intelligence initiatives. As well as authorizing the detention of communist agents and sympathizers, it sanctioned their torture and assassination.

Hunted down

The first task of Phoenix personnel in any operation was to identify the communist leadership in each province, district, and village. Thousands of committees were set up to gather information on individuals and compile lists of names. In theory, accusations had to be confirmed by at least three independent sources before suspects could be interrogated.

Arrests—usually made at night when the accused were sleeping—were made by Provincial Reconnaissance Units (PRUs): paramilitary teams comprising South Vietnamese security officers, the CIA, and the US military, including Special Forces and Navy Seals. The PRU then took the accused to a provincial interrogation center, where he or she could be detained for up to two years without trial. At their height, there were some 4,000 PRUs. Their members in South Vietnam were assigned to districts in which they already had contacts.

Their job was not easy. Much of the countryside, especially around the Mekong Delta, was effectively controlled by the Viet Cong. At the outset of the program, it was estimated that around 70,000 individuals were actively working for the communists in South Vietnam, and thousands of sympathizers performed small duties or favors for the cause.

81,000 The estimated number of communist cadres “neutralized”—killed, captured, or forced to defect—by the Phoenix Program. It is estimated that up to half this number were killed.